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Why Should I Forgive?

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Why Should I Forgive?

Get rid of all bitterness, rage and anger, brawling and slander, along with every form of malice. Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you. (Ephesians 4:31-32)

Love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you. (Matthew 5:44, NKJV)

It is no surprise to any of us that we need to forgive others. If we know we are to do it, why is it so hard? Why do we always want to tell our side? Why do we always argue our case as the exception to scripture's command on forgiveness? Is there an exception, a time when we don't have to forgive?

You can search a long time and you won't find a command to NOT forgive. God is very clear to His children. In the Matthew verse above we find four different ways that people can hurt us. They are our enemies; they curse us, hate us, and spitefully use us or persecute us. That covers just about all the bad things that people can do to us. Yet, what does God tell us to do? We are to love, bless, do good, and pray for these people. Our natural instinct is to get angry, be bitter, brawl, and slander them. The Ephesians verse tells us that we need to get rid of all of those things. The next command is to be kind, compassionate and forgiving. Why? Because that is what Jesus Christ did for us...He forgave.

If we understand what Jesus did for us, we will be giving the same gift to each other. Just in the same way that we did not deserve the wonderful gift we received, we can give the same gift of forgiveness to those who have harmed us. Guess what? The gift goes both ways. We give the gift of forgiveness to the other person, but you receive the freedom that forgiving gives you. You are literally let out of the prison that unforgiveness puts you in. Forgiveness is the key to your freedom.

Unforgiveness shackles you to the person you won't forgive. You drag them and the resentment you feel around all day long like a ball and chain. If you have more than one person that you refuse to forgive, you will find, after awhile, that you are very tired. Unforgiveness is exhausting. It takes a lot of energy to carry around grudges. Are you ready to walk in freedom?

Take some time to sit down and evaluate your relationships. Can someone walk into the room and ruin your day? Is there someone you refuse to see or call because they have hurt you and you have not dealt with your heart in the matter? Do it today. Before you call, call upon the Lord. Forgive them as Jesus forgave you, and then you are ready to make that call.